

KEY MOMENT

THE BATTLE OF WINCHESTER

On May 25, 1862, Jackson's 16,000 Confederates advanced on Winchester in hot pursuit of Banks's 7,000 retreating Union soldiers. Although exhausted by marches and firefights, the Confederate troops maintained their momentum, preventing Banks from consolidating a defensive line. Jackson's forces attacked the Union right, while Ewell's small force put pressure on their left. After serious fighting, in which General Richard Taylor's Louisiana Brigade played a key role, the Union troops withdrew through the town and on to the Potomac River. Jackson's weary men failed to mount a vigorous pursuit, but they had taken Winchester.

Union forces diverted

President Lincoln was pushed into the aggressive response that Confederate strategy had desired. He diverted a corps under Brigadier General Irvin McDowell, previously bound for Richmond, into the Valley to join with Frémont and Banks in an operation to trap and destroy Jackson's army. Together they would have 60,000 men to Jackson's 17,000. Alert to the danger, Jackson drove his men by a series of forced marches from the environs of Harpers Ferry back through Strasburg—just before a Union pincer movement would have cut the road—to the only surviving bridge across the South Fork of the Shenandoah River at Port Republic. The Confederates had marched 140 miles (225km) in a week, losing hundreds of stragglers along the way. Now Jackson and Ewell turned their forces to face their pursuers.

Two Union columns, led respectively by Frémont and Shields, advanced on Port Republic. They were separated by the river, the Confederates controlling the only bridge. Ewell's division met Frémont's troops at Cross Keys on June 8 and repelled them, despite a Union numerical advantage of almost two to one. The following day two brigades of Shields's division reached Port Royal and narrowly failed to seize the bridge—almost capturing Jackson as well. Jackson's troops fought back, forcing the Union forces to quit the field after heavy losses on both sides. As neither Frémont nor Shields chose to renew the fighting, the Shenandoah Valley Campaign came to an end.